

Skills Summary

Adding, Subtracting, and Missing Numbers to 20

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

First ask: what is this one asking?

- **Plus sign, blank at the end** → put the groups together. Words that go with it: *and, more, altogether, in all*.
- **Minus sign, blank at the end** → take some away. Words that go with it: *eats, gives away, left, how many are gone*.
- **Blank at the start or in the middle** → a number is missing. Words that go with it: *how many more, how many to get to*.

The = sign means *the same as*. Whatever you write in the blank, both sides have to match.

1. Adding to 20: make a ten

Ten is the easiest number to add to, so build one first. Take just enough from the second number to fill the first one up to 10, then add what is left over. Adding in either order gives the same total, so start from the bigger number to save hops.

Example: $8 + 6$

Step 1. The blank is at the end and the sign is plus, so I am putting two groups together — and I can make a ten to do it quickly.

Step 2. 8 needs 2 more to reach ten, and 6 is 2 and 4. So $8 + 2 = 10$, and $10 + 4$ is next. $8 + 6 = 14$

Try it: $9 + 4 = ?$

check: 13

2. Subtracting to 20: get down to ten, or think addition

Two safe ways. **Down to ten:** take away just enough to land on 10, then take away the rest. **Think addition:** ask what you would add to the smaller number to get back to the bigger one — subtraction and addition undo each other, so the answer is the same.

Example: $15 - 8$

Step 1. Minus sign with the blank at the end, so something is being taken away — and 15 is close to ten, so I will step down to ten first.

Step 2. $15 - 5 = 10$, and there are 3 still to take away, so $10 - 3$ comes next. Check it by adding back. $15 - 8 = 7$

Try it: $14 - 6 = ?$

check: 8

3. Finding the missing number

When the blank is not at the end, do not just add or subtract the two numbers you can see. Read the sentence out loud instead, then **count on** from the smaller number to the bigger one and count your hops. Always check by putting your answer into the original sentence.

Example: $6 + \underline{\quad} = 13$

Step 1. The blank sits in the middle, so this is asking how far it is from 6 up to 13 — not what 6 and 13 make together.

Step 2. Count on from 6: four hops reach ten, then three more hops reach thirteen, so that is seven hops in all. $6 + 7 = 13$

Try it: $5 + \underline{\quad} = 14$

check: 6

(!) Watch out: The $=$ sign does not mean “the answer comes next”. In $7 + \underline{\quad} = 15$ the answer goes in the middle, and adding 7 and 15 would be wrong. Cover the blank with your finger and say the sentence aloud before you write anything.